



War of attrition: Having stunned Germany in the previous round, Paraguay refused to abandon its streetwise, confrontational approach against France, making Didier Deschamps' side earn every yard in a tense Round of 16 encounter. AFP

came on a night when luck and judgement went against it. Well aware of its limitations, for 78 minutes, Egypt had title-holder Argentina by the scruff of the neck with brilliant counter-attacking football, while custodian Mostafa Shobeir denied Lionel Messi from the spot. But then perhaps the lack of experience finally caught up as Argentina mounted a late comeback, which, according to the Egyptian players and staff, was aided by injustice.

The loss may have left a sour

taste, but Egypt's run is sure to reassure this crop of players that they truly belong on the world's biggest stage.

In some cases, the impact of these teams proved to be buzzkills rather than examples of attractive football. Paraguay, for example, came with a solid game plan to prevent opponents from recreating their pre-planned routines. Despite a demoralising 1-4 loss against the USA in the first group game, one more goal in the next two games

was enough for Gustavo Alfaro's side to progress as one of the third-placed teams.

The next two contests against two European giants saw the side embrace the role of the pantomime villain. The approach worked a treat against Germany, with *La Albirroja's* physical game entirely disrupting the tactically sophisticated setup of Julian Nagelsmann. The defensive shutout, followed by Orlando Gill's inspired performance between the sticks in the penalty shootout,

« Underdogs may lack history or glamour, but their spirit and charisma often make them the neutrals' favourites »